prayers were restrained from saying anything that would create differences among the people.

The R&AW spies observed:

In view of the wide divergence of views between the two antagonistic factions, it is extremely doubtful whether the deep-rooted differences among them could be ironed out easily and some semblance of cooperation forged for tackling the burning problems affecting the nation, including the conduct of the war. More probably the task of Khomeini, who has so far been performing a balancing feat, is likely to be rendered more difficult.

In the meantime, the R&AW agents noted the mass exodus of Indian workers from Iraq and Iran since that was a telltale sign that the war would be prolonged one. A special department of the MEA was created to ensure the safe return of Indian workers and arrangements were made to issue transit visas and travel documents on the spot. Around eleven thousand Indians were evacuated from Iran and Iraq, while seventeen people were killed and thirty injured. Under the shadow of war, the IndoIraqi joint commission meeting was held in New Delhi in April 1981 to strengthen economic cooperation. Back in Iraq, the R&AW watched Saddam Hussein's growing strength and the crackdown against the moles in his Ba'ath Party. The Indian agents reported: 'Several Shia members of the Ba'ath Party were reported to have been taken into custody on suspicion of their links to opposition groups. The process of screening of the Shia officers in the army was also continuing. According to a report, some army officers including three Brigadiers were executed in Baghdad at the end of last month on charges of disloyalty or incompetence.'